But Now Is Christ Risen

Christianity stands or falls on the resurrection of Jesus, and because he is risen, our faith is not in vain and death is not the end.

Main passage	1 Corinthians 15:12-22 (KJV)
Topic	Resurrection
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: If Christ is not raised, everything collapses	7 min
Teaching point 2: But now is Christ risen	7 min
Teaching point 3: The firstfruits: death is not the end	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "If someone could prove that Jesus did not rise from the dead, what would be left of Christianity?" Some will say his teaching and his example. Then tell them Paul's surprising answer: without the resurrection, nothing is left. This lesson is ideal for Easter but belongs to every Sunday, since every Sunday celebrates the resurrection.

Scripture (3 min)

1 Corinthians 15:12-22

12 Now if Christ be preached that he rose from the dead, how say some among you that there is no resurrection of the dead? 13 But if there be no resurrection of the dead, then is Christ not risen: 14 And if Christ be not risen, then is our preaching vain, and your faith is also vain. 15 Yea, and we are found false witnesses of God; because we have testified of God that he raised up Christ: whom he raised not up, if so be

that the dead rise not. [16] For if the dead rise not, then is not Christ raised: [17] And if Christ be not raised, your faith is vain; ye are yet in your sins. [18] Then they also which are fallen asleep in Christ are perished. [19] If in this life only we have hope in Christ, we are of all men most miserable. [20] But now is Christ risen from the dead, and become the firstfruits of them that slept. [21] For since by man came death, by man came also the resurrection of the dead. [22] For as in Adam all die, even so in Christ shall all be made alive.

Read the passage aloud. Read verse 20 with extra emphasis.

Background (5 min)

Some in the Corinthian church were saying "there is no resurrection of the dead" (v. 12). Greek thinking often treated the body as a prison and hoped for the soul's escape from it; a bodily resurrection seemed crude or impossible. Paul answers in the longest discussion of resurrection in the Bible.

In verses 1-11 he summarizes the gospel and lists witnesses of the risen Jesus: Peter, the Twelve, more than five hundred at once (most of whom were still alive and could be asked), James, all the apostles and Paul himself. Then in verses 12-19 he follows the logic: if the dead do not rise, Christ did not rise either.

Teaching point 1: If Christ is not raised, everything collapses (7 min)

Paul is brutally honest. If Christ is not risen, preaching is empty, faith is empty, the apostles are liars, we are still in our sins, and believers who have died are lost (vv. 14-18). If our hope in Christ is for this life only, we are of all people most to be pitied. Christianity is not just good advice; it stands on an event in history.

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 15:12-19 (read from the Bible)

Romans 4:25: Who was delivered for our offences, and was raised again for our justification.

Acts 17:31: Because he hath appointed a day, in the which he will judge the world in righteousness by that man whom he hath ordained; whereof he hath given assurance unto all men, in that he hath raised him from the dead.

> *"Our whole doctrine is useless, nugatory and false."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 15:14

> *"their faith was vain, because, if Christ was not raised up, they were yet unpardoned sinners."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 15:17

Handout blanks (answers)

If Christ be not risen, then is our preaching **vain**.

If Christ be not raised, ye are yet in your **sins**.

Teaching point 2: But now is Christ risen (7 min)

Verse 20 turns the whole chapter: "But now is Christ risen from the dead." Paul has looked into the abyss of a world without the resurrection, and he steps back onto solid ground. The tomb was empty, and many witnesses saw the risen Lord. Everything Paul feared in verses 14-19 is reversed.

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 15:20: But now is Christ risen from the dead, and become the firstfruits of them that slept.

Luke 24:1-8 (read from the Bible)

1 Corinthians 15:3-8 (read from the Bible)

> *"This language is the bursting forth of a full heart and of overpowering conviction."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 15:20

Handout blanks (answers)

But now is Christ **risen** from the dead.

Christianity rests on an **event** in history.

Teaching point 3: The firstfruits: death is not the end (7 min)

Christ is the "firstfruits of them that slept." The firstfruits were the first sheaf of the harvest, offered to God as a pledge that the whole harvest would follow. Jesus' resurrection guarantees ours. Death came through Adam; life comes through Christ. That is why believers who die are said to have "fallen asleep."

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 15:20-22: But now is Christ risen from the dead, and become the firstfruits of them that slept. For since by man came death, by man came also the resurrection of the dead. For as in Adam all die, even so in Christ shall all be made alive.

John 11:25-26: Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live: And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die. Believest thou this?

1 Thessalonians 4:13-14: But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope. For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him.

> *"Mortality came by Adam, immortality by Christ; so sure as all have been subjected to natural death by Adam, so sure shall all be raised again by Christ Jesus."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 15:21

> *"In Christ's case the term used is death, to assure us of the reality of His suffering; in our case, sleep, to give us consolation"*
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 1 Corinthians 15:18

Handout blanks (answers)

Christ is become the **firstfruits** of them that slept.

As in Adam all die, even so in Christ shall all be made **alive**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why does Paul say we would be "most miserable" if our hope in Christ were for this life only?

We would have given up much for a hope that was false, and believers who died would simply be gone.

2. Why does it matter that the resurrection was bodily, not just spiritual?

It means God redeems the whole person and the physical world; death is defeated, not just escaped.

3. What does "firstfruits" tell us about our own future?

Jesus' resurrection is the first part of the harvest that guarantees the rest; ours will follow.

4. How should the resurrection change the way Christians grieve?

We still grieve, but "not as others which have no hope" (1 Thessalonians 4:13).

Application (3 min)

Think of one fear or grief that the resurrection speaks to. Write 1 Corinthians 15:20 on a card and put it where you will see it daily. This week, tell someone why you believe Jesus rose from the dead.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Risen Lord Jesus, thank you that you are not in the grave. Because you live, our faith is not in vain and our sins are forgiven. Because you are the firstfruits, death is not the end for those who belong to you. Fill us with living hope and the courage to share it. Alleluia, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 15:14

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 15:17

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